

"אין שמחה כשמחת התורה"

"אשרי מי שבא לכאן ותלמודו בידו"

When my uncle, Dr. Leslie Bennett, שליט"א, called me and asked if I would write a *haskamah* for this *sefer*, I was genuinely shocked. After confirming that I had heard him correctly, I believe my response was, "My *haskamah* would be worthless." To which Uncle Leslie replied, in his inimitable fashion, "But it would be worth something to me."

As many of the readers of this *sefer* will undoubtedly be members of the extended Bennett *mishpachah*, I think I can safely say - without offending anyone - that Bennetts always have something to say. And while many times there is Torah being shared, with Uncle Leslie, I would be hard-pressed to think of a time when Torah was *not* shared.

It is no wonder that throughout my childhood (and I would assume until today) Uncle Leslie was the peddler of *parsha* pamphlets and Torah sheets in our shul. Although a physician by profession, Uncle Leslie is, at heart, an educator. He simply cannot keep a beautiful piece of Torah to himself. Whenever he encounters a *vort* that inspires him or a *chiddush* that captivates him, he feels compelled to share it so that others can appreciate it as well.

I believe Uncle Leslie and I share a common passion: a love for a *geshmakeh vort*. I certainly cannot be the only one who has experienced seeing him over Shabbos, only to have a *parshah* sheet or *sefer* enthusiastically thrust into my hands with the simple instruction: "Read this."

And if I am the only one, then I consider it an honor.

Whether it was an inspiring story, a thought-provoking and original *chiddush*, or an intricate mathematical *gematria*, it was always something that enriched my Shabbos, deepened my appreciation of that week's *parshah*, and, by extension, enhanced my family's as well. I may not always have told him so, but many of Uncle Leslie's "*chiddushim*" remained in my back pocket for years and were subsequently shared with countless *talmidim* of my own.

Perusing through this *sefer*, as I normally do with *seforim al haTorah*, I started with *Parshas Bereishis* and then flipped to this week's *parsha* (*Parshas Eikev*). True to form, I found myself moved to tears by the story in Bereishis תשפ"ו, only to be captivated moments later by the *Megaleh Amukos* (whose *yahrtzeit* is today, י"ג אב, תשפ"ה) cited in Eikev תשפ"ה.

The title of this *sefer*, הדבר בי, drawn from the זכריה הנביא of נבואה, referring to the מלאך who spoke to זכריה, is appropriately titled so, as it can also homiletically be understood as בי - יששכר בנימין - who speaks. The *Divrei Torah* contained within are the very messages Uncle Leslie faithfully delivered to the family week after week. Yet the title is expressed in the present tense rather than the past, because these teachings are timeless. They continue to speak to us today and will continue to do so for years to come. Through this *sefer*, readers can once again experience those weekly *divrei Torah* in a style remarkably faithful to the way Uncle Leslie originally delivered them.

The title also hints to the inclusion of Aunt Devorah (דברה = הדבר) in this accomplishment, which cannot be overstated. Aunt Devorah, a powerhouse in her own right, has devotedly stood by Uncle Leslie's side in his myriad accomplishments: raising their family, the medical profession, as a community askan, as the patriarch of our family, and as a Ben Torah and Talmid Chochom.

Tremendous credit is likewise due to Reb Ari Bennett (a chavrusah of my father, ע"ה, during the final years of his life) who painstakingly transcribed the video shiurim of Uncle Leslie, reviewed each מאמר and whose meticulous organizational and technological prowess brought this sefer, מכח אל הפועל.

"דברי תורה עניים במקום אחד ועשירים, teach us in the third perek of the Yerushalmi in Rosh Hashana, Uncle Leslie has spent a lifetime collecting these beautiful divrei Torah wherever he found them and generously sharing them with everyone around him. Now, through this sefer, that generosity extends far beyond the walls of his home and shul, allowing countless others to benefit from the Torah that has enriched our family for so many years.

May this sefer serve as a z'chus for Uncle Leslie and Aunt Devorah, our entire mishpacha - those in olam hazeh and those in the olam ha'emes - and, by the time you read this, may we be heralding the coming of Moshiach Tzidkeinu.

Yossi Bennett
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י"ג אב תשפ"ו
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